

Filling last-minute openings without the group-text scramble

Today a cancellation means Lena or Carla scan the Google Sheet, text several people from the salon phone, and try to remember who answered. Chairs stay empty during busy stretches, two people say yes to the same slot, and late replies cause confusion.

WHAT HURTS

- Losing track of who was contacted and who declined
- Forgetting to text the next person when it's busy
- Several people texted at once → more than one "yes"
- Late replies after someone else already accepted

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

- Openings move to the next eligible person on their own
- Never two people claiming the same slot
- At a glance: who has the offer, time left, who's next
- **Goal: at least half of last-minute cancellations refilled**

HOW THE PROTOTYPE BEHAVES

One opening → one offer at a time → one winner

1 · CANCELLATION

Staff enter the opening: stylist, time, length. Square isn't touched.



2 · MATCH

Waitlist filtered by service (and its length fitting the gap), availability and requested stylist, in the order they joined.



3 · OFFER

First person is texted. They get 15 minutes (configurable) to reply YES or NO.



4 · OUTCOME

YES → filled, others told. NO / no reply / skip → next person. Nobody left → staff told it's unfilled.

RULES LENA SET

- Only the person currently holding the offer can accept; a late or duplicate YES is politely refused
- Staff can *skip* the current person or *cancel* the opening at any time
- Offering stops when it's too close to the appointment (default 30 min; cutoff still Lena's call)
- Winner's original booking is moved by staff in Square, by hand

WHY TEMPORAL MATTERS HERE

- Each opening is a durable Workflow: the 15-minute timer, the queue position and every reply survive restarts and crashes
- Replies are Temporal *Updates*, so "first YES wins" is enforced in one place, not in a spreadsheet
- Texts are retried automatically if the SMS provider hiccups
- The dashboard is just a view of the Workflow's state: reload, reopen, still correct

Scope of this prototype

AREA	STATUS	NOTES
Offer sequencing, timers, one winner, staff skip/cancel, status view	Working	Covered by Workflow tests (time-skipping) and browser end-to-end tests: accept, expiry → next offer, stale and duplicate replies, queue-jumping, skip, cancel, reload mid-offer. Worker restart mid-offer was checked manually (see evidence/).
Text messages	Simulated	Texts are logged and shown on a simulated "client phone". Client replies are a button in the demo; in production an SMS webhook maps the phone number to the reply.
Waitlist data	Simulated	A hard-coded copy of the spreadsheet (six clients). Reading the live Google Sheet is a small Activity change.
Square	Excluded	At Lena's request. The app never reads or writes Square; staff book the winner and move their original appointment manually.
Staff notifications	Simulated	"Filled / unfilled / cancelled" goes to the dashboard and server log, not yet to the salon phone.
Logins, multiple locations, reporting	Excluded	Local prototype only; not deployed.

NEXT STEP

A two-week trial on real cancellations

WHAT WE'D DO

- Connect a real SMS number (Twilio or Square Messages) with an inbound webhook, so clients reply by text, not a button
- Read the live waitlist sheet instead of the copy
- Send the filled / unfilled alert to the salon phone
- Run it alongside the current process for two weeks; staff keep the final say in Square

WHAT WE'D MEASURE

- Share of last-minute cancellations refilled (target: $\geq 50\%$)
- Minutes from cancellation to a confirmed YES
- Double-acceptances (should be zero)
- How often staff skip or cancel, to tune the reply window and the "too close" cutoff

Decisions needed from Lena: the "too close to the appointment" cutoff, and whether an accepted client stays on the waitlist.